Boxiong, vice chairman of the CMC, and other defence officials. While shaking hands with the vice president and conveying the good wishes of our people, I summoned the courage to say, 'Excellency, when our two nations shake hands, the world sits up to watch.' He smiled. We agreed to hold the first-ever defence dialogue in New Delhi in a few months' time and also agreed upon the modalities of joint training between the two armies to be held once a year. For army officers of our generation and our predecessors who had been through the 1962 showdown, this was something incredible. The same may have been the case on the Chinese side.

On my farewell visit to HQ Eastern Command during September 2007, an interesting incident concerning China happened quite innocuously. In my customary interaction with the media, I was asked a number of questions relating to my visit to China and the infrastructure being built in Tibet. My response covered the extremely positive developments in our bilateral relations, the confidence-building measures in place and so on. The media was not satisfied and continued harping on the point that we were not doing enough to meet the future challenges. I assumed that the media was projecting the feelings of the people. Therefore, to give them the desired level of reassurance, I highlighted with great emphasis that we were doing everything that was required to improve our capabilities and the infrastructure so that we could effectively respond to any challenge, and that 1962 would not be repeated.

The next day we were amazed to learn from ambassador Nirupama Rao that the Chinese foreign office had queried her if the Indian army chief had issued a warning to China! We were quite surprised as no such thing had happened. When we checked up on this, it turned out that one of the media reports had titled the story of my interaction in Kolkata – 'Indian Army Chief warns China against misadventure.' The heading given by the editor had no relationship with the text of the article. Nirupama Rao deftly explained to the Chinese that this was an example of irresponsible and sensational reporting by an element of our free media. Fortunately the issue was not allowed to be blown out of proportion by this timely intervention.